

I told him this, which led to a very candid discussion. We talked openly about George's wishes and how tenable they were. It's a hard conversation to have with your parents, because no one wants to talk about the finances of dying. But it is a conversation you must have. Many people are finding that their golden years turn out to be not so golden after all. There is nothing wrong with hoping for the best—as long as you prepare for the worst.

The worst can come in many forms. For the aging baby boomer population, it often involves our parents. If there are severe health problems, you may be thrust into the role of caretaker, and your parents could become your dependents—a painful inversion of former roles. The worst could also involve your partner. We all know people who've received that dreaded phone call: "Your husband has been in a car accident." "Your wife has stage III cancer." Some of us may even experience the worst in our own lives: a dire medical diagnosis in the midst of a successful career, health that declines far more rapidly than we imagined.



Here is my stepfather, George, working on his "to be consulted on my death" document.

Preparing his estate this way was a gift to my brother and me. Organizing for the inevitable does not have to be morbid; it was an excuse for us to get together and forced our family to make some decisions while all of us could still participate.